



three Tests to manage his workload, Siraj is coming off a limited-overs snub, Mohammad Shami's persistent fitness issues have ruled him out, and Prasidh Krishna, Akash Deep and Arshdeep Singh have never played a Test in England. But optimising scarce resources is the name of the game, and for starters, the Indian team management will want to nail down the three matches it wants Bumrah to feature in.

The blueprint of the 2021 series in England offers an intriguing insight. Bumrah outshone his bowling partners in the three matches India

failed to win — at Nottingham, Leeds and Edgbaston — averaging 19.43 for his 16 wickets, as compared to his peers' 26 wickets at 48.80. However, in the victories at Lord's and The Oval, Bumrah's bowling average of 29.42 paled in comparison to his teammates' 24.63.

Bumrah's ability to take the pitch and conditions out of the equation owing to his unique skills, facilitated by his even more unique bowling action, makes him an ideal candidate for venues where his teammates could struggle.

Among the five venues for the

upcoming series, The Oval (fifth Test), Manchester (fourth Test), and Leeds (first Test) have produced the least amount of swing since 2021. Given Bumrah's ability to transcend conditions, playing him at these venues could help India optimise his availability.

In the absence of Shami, India will need to identify a new-ball bowler to partner Bumrah. While Siraj seems to be an obvious choice, his skills are best utilised with a semi-old ball (30–59 overs old). His average dropped to 27.8 from 36.50 when operating with an older ball during